

SAVE THE HOSTAGE!

The following combat encounter is Hard for **five level 3 heroes**. You can modify the details of this encounter as you see fit, replacing any of the named concepts with elements from your own campaign.

Taken By Cultists

The heroes are tasked by a panicked villager to save their spouse Finn, who was taken by a cult of goblins during an attack on their trading caravan. The villager's home is small and can't muster a rescue party, so Finn was left for dead.

The last few times one of their neighbors was abducted, their mangled body was found floating downstream from the old fort a few days later. The villager suspects that their spouse's time is limited, and it's up to the heroes to save Finn before their fate is sealed.

Lautan Keep

When the heroes reach the valley, provide the following information:

- ♦ "A fortress stands in the valley, forming an impenetrable gray barricade between the mountains."
- ♦ "A river winds its way through the field, running under an earthen ramp to the keep's primary entrance and through a portcullis leading beyond the fortress."
- ♦ "The outer walls have seen better days. Large cracks have been gouged directly into the structure's foundations from years of failed assaults. But today, tight caverns peek out from the cracks."
- ♦ "A foul odor of sulfur wafts both from a cave underneath the primary entrance and the wall adjacent to the river."
- ♦ "Goblins and bugbears can be seen among the parapets and scattered throughout the field, armed but inattentive."

Eight **goblin runners**, two **goblin underbosses**, and a **bugbear roughneck** guard the field, while eight **goblin snipers** and a **bugbear commander** watch from the ramparts. Inside the keep, eight **goblin spincleavers** protect a **bugbear commander** as they perform a ritual on their hostage, **Finn**.

The goblins are sluggish; they won't sound the alarms until a goblin is attacked or a hero comes within 4 squares of one.

Castle Walls

The castle walls are 4 squares high and slippery. Any hero without the Climbing skill must use a maneuver in addition to a move action to ascend the walls.

Black Powder

The cultists have managed to secure a trove of black powder barrels, storing them underneath the primary entrance to the keep and the portcullis as a poorly thought-out contingency plan for destroying the entrances. There are five barrels in total. A hero can use a maneuver on their turn to light each barrel within reach during their move action. A barrel explodes at the start of the next round after it was lit, dealing 20 fire damage to each adjacent creature and instantly destroying each adjacent object. A blown-up segment of the keep turns into rubble and is considered difficult terrain.

Encounter Credits

Designer: Diana Voyer

Editor: Graeme Bloodworth

Encounter Map: The MAD Cartographer

Playtest Contractor: Spencer Hibnick

Playtest Coordinators: Aaron Flavius West, Gina Devlin, Casey Williams, Joel Russ, Anna/Nathan Lee

Playtest Contributors: Alex Rousseau, Jesse Ferguson, Adam Scholze, Tamwin Le'Feur, Robert Lane, Cameron Baker

The Gates

The fortress gates are especially sturdy and will withstand a black powder explosion. However, the cracks in the adjacent walls have revealed the weakened support pillars of the gates. The gate over the river has two pillars as its foundation, while the main gate to the fortress is supported by three pillars. Blowing up all of a gate's pillars will cause the gates to fall.

The gate cranks are operable, but they require two heroes to use their main action to turn both of them within the same round in order to open the gate.

The Ritual

Finn isn't particularly important to the ritual; the cult could perform their rites to their god with any humanoid. Unfortunately, the ritual is already underway, and the hostage takes 1 damage at the end of each round as they are cut and tortured.

When a hero enters the chamber containing the bugbear commander and Finn, they decide it's time to finish the ritual. If left uninterrupted, the commander kills the hostage at the end of the next round. However, if the commander becomes winded, they instead solely focus on killing the heroes.

Should they complete their rites, each remaining cultist surges with power and chases the heroes out of the keep; they've made their god proud yet again and are rewarded with strength until the next ritual.

The Hostage

Finn is gagged and actively screaming in pain and terror. If the gag is removed, the poor villager doesn't do much other than plead for their life, unable to quite recognize the heroes as their rescue. Once Lautan is cleared, or if the heroes manage to bring the hostage out of the keep, Finn slowly starts to regain understanding and tearfully thanks the heroes after a while. The longer it took the heroes to rescue Finn, the longer it takes for the villager to come to their senses.

Groups

Group	Creatures
1	One bugbear commander (captain) Four goblin snipers (minion squad) Four goblin snipers (minion squad)
2	Two goblin underbosses (captain) Four goblin runners (minion squad) Four goblin runners (minion squad)
3	One bugbear roughneck
4	One bugbear commander (captain) Four goblin spincleavers (minion squad) Four goblin spincleavers (minion squad)

Adjusting the Encounter

Heroes	Adjustments
3	Remove one bugbear roughneck and one goblin underboss .
4	Remove one bugbear roughneck .
6	Replace the goblin underbosses with a bugbear roughneck .

Tactics

The goal of the goblins on the field and the ramparts is to keep the heroes out of their keep. They start by trying to drive the heroes away before moving to more lethal means. The roughneck is eager to use Drag Through Hell whenever they have the opportunity. Once the heroes are inside the fortress, all goblins not performing the ritual focus entirely on killing the intruders.

Ending the Encounter

The heroes are successful if they save Finn from the cult. The heroes earn 2 Victories each if the hostage is alive when the party escapes.

The heroes fail the encounter if Finn is killed or each hero is defeated.

Rewards

There are **two healing potions** sitting on the floor near the hostage where the ritual takes place, along with dozens of empty bottles that formerly contained them.

Finn

Humanoid

1M Size	5 Speed	10 Stamina	0 Stability	1 Free Strike
Immunity: — Movement: —				
Might 0	Agility 0	Reason 0	Intuition 0	Presence 0

Goblin Malice

Malice Feature

At the start of any goblin's turn, you can spend malice to activate one of the following features.

★ **Goblin Mode** 3 Malice
Each goblin in the encounter gains a +2 bonus to speed until the end of the round.

★ **Grab Iron Ball** 3+ Malice
For every 3 Malice spent, one non-minion bugbear acting this turn grabs an iron ball and can use a maneuver to throw it at a creature within 5 squares of them. The creature takes damage equal to 8 – the number of squares the iron ball was thrown, and if they have **M < 1**, they are slowed (save ends).

★ **Grab Javelin** 5+ Malice
For every 5 Malice spent, one non-minion bugbear acting this turn grabs a javelin and can use a maneuver to throw it at a creature within 5 squares of them. The creature takes damage equal to 12 – the number of squares the javelin was thrown, and if they have **M < 1**, they are bleeding (save ends). While a creature is bleeding this way, any ally of the bugbear within 2 squares of them can use a free maneuver to pull the bleeding creature up to 2 squares.

Goblin Runner

Goblin, Humanoid

Level 1 Minion Harrier

EV 3 for four minions

1S Size	6 Speed	4 Stamina	0 Stability	1 Free Strike
Immunity: — Movement: Climb		Weakness: — With Captain: Gain an edge on strikes		

Might -2 Agility +2 Reason 0 Intuition 0 Presence -1

✂ **Club Charge** 2d10 + 2
Charge, Melee, Strike, Weapon
Melee 1
One creature or object per minion
1d11 1 damage
1d12-16 2 damage
1d17+ 3 damage

Signature Ability

Main action

★ Crafty

The runner doesn't provoke opportunity attacks by moving.

Goblin Spinecleaver

Goblin, Humanoid

Level 1 Minion Brute

EV 3 for four minions

1S Size	5 Speed	5 Stamina	0 Stability	2 Free Strike
Immunity: — Movement: Climb		Weakness: — With Captain: +1 damage bonus to strikes		

Might +2 Agility 0 Reason 0 Intuition 0 Presence -1

✂ **Axe** 2d10 + 2
Melee, Strike, Weapon
Melee 1
One creature or object per minion
1d11 2 damage; push 1
1d12-16 4 damage; push 3
1d17+ 5 damage; push 4

Signature Ability

Main action

★ Crafty

The spinecleaver doesn't provoke opportunity attacks by moving.

Goblin Underboss

Goblin, Humanoid

Level 1 Horde Support

EV 3

1S Size	5 Speed	15 Stamina	0 Stability	1 Free Strike
Immunity: — Movement: Climb		Weakness: —		

Might -1 Agility +2 Reason 0 Intuition 0 Presence +1

✂ **Swordplay** 2d10 + 2
Melee, Strike, Weapon
Melee 1
One creature or object
1d11 3 damage
1d12-16 4 damage
1d17+ 5 damage
Effect: One ally adjacent to the target can make a free strike against them.

Signature Ability

Main action

✂ Get Reckless!

Area

5 burst

Maneuver

Each ally in the area

Effect: Until the start of the underboss's next turn, each target gains an edge on strikes, and any strike made against a target gains an edge.

2 Malice: Strikes made against targets no longer gain an edge.

★ Crafty

The underboss doesn't provoke opportunity attacks by moving.

Bugbear Commander

Bugbear, Fey, Goblin, Humanoid

Level 2 Elite Support

EV 16

1L
Size5
Speed80
Stamina0
Stability5
Free StrikeImmunity: —
Movement: —

Weakness: —

Might +2 **A**gility +1 **R**eason +2 **I**ntuition 0 **P**resence 0

Inspiring Swordplay 2d10 + 2 **Signature Ability**
Melee, Strike, Weapon Main action
 Melee 1 Two creatures or objects
(≤11) 7 damage
(12-16) 10 damage
(17+) 13 damage; one target is grabbed
Effect: One ally within 5 squares of the commander gains an edge on their next strike until the start of the commander's next turn.

You Next!
Ranged Main action
 Ranged 8 One ally
Effect: The target moves up to their speed and uses a signature ability.

Fall Back! **5 Malice**
Area Maneuver
 5 burst Each ally in the area
Effect: Each target shifts up to their speed, then can use the Throw maneuver.

Throw
Melee, Strike Maneuver
 Melee 1 One creature or object
Special: The target must be grabbed by the commander.
Effect: The target is vertical pushed up to 4 squares. An ally doesn't take damage from being force moved this way

Catcher
Melee Free triggered action
 Melee 1 The triggering creature or object
Trigger: A size 1 creature or object is force moved within distance, or a size 1 ally willingly moves within distance.
Effect: The target is grabbed by the commander.

★ **The Commander's Watching**
Any ally who has line of effect to the commander can end one condition on themselves at the start of each of their turns.

Goblin Sniper

Goblin, Humanoid

Level 1 Minion Artillery

EV 3 for four minions

1S
Size5
Speed3
Stamina0
Stability2
Free StrikeImmunity: —
Movement: Climb

Weakness: —

With Captain: +5 bonus to ranged distance**M**ight -2 **A**gility +2 **R**eason 0 **I**ntuition 0 **P**resence -1

Bow 2d10 + 2 **Signature Ability**
Ranged, Strike, Weapon Main action
 Ranged 10 One creature or object per minion
(≤11) 2 damage
(12-16) 4 damage
(17+) 5 damage
Effect: If the sniper doesn't use a move action this turn, this ability gains an edge.

★ **Crafty**
The sniper doesn't provoke opportunity attacks by moving.

Bugbear Roughneck

Bugbear, Fey, Goblin, Humanoid

Level 2 Elite Brute

EV 16

1L
Size6
Speed109
Stamina0
Stability5
Free StrikeImmunity: —
Movement: —

Weakness: —

Might +2 **A**gility +2 **R**eason 0 **I**ntuition 0 **P**resence 0

Haymaker 2d10 + 2 **Signature Ability**
Melee, Strike, Weapon Main action
 Melee 1 Two creatures or objects
(≤11) 7 damage
(12-16) 11 damage; one target is grabbed; one target is pushed up to 2 squares
(17+) 14 damage; one target is grabbed; one target is vertical pushed up to 3 squares

5 Malice: The ability takes the Area keyword and loses the Strike keyword, its distance becomes a 1 burst, and it targets each enemy in the area.

Leaping Fury 2d10 + 2
Melee, Strike, Weapon Main action
 Melee 1 One creature or object
(≤11) 8 damage; **M**<1 prone
(12-16) 13 damage; **M**<2 prone
(17+) 16 damage; **M**<3 prone
Effect: The roughneck can jump up to 5 squares to an unoccupied space within distance of the target before making this strike.

Drag Through Hell **3 Malice**
Melee Maneuver
 Melee 1 One creature or object
Special: The target must be grabbed by the roughneck.
Effect: The roughneck moves up to their speed across the ground, dragging the target with them. The target takes 2 damage for each square they were dragged through. When this movement ends, the target is no longer grabbed and falls prone. Each square the target was dragged through is difficult terrain for enemies.

Throw
Melee, Strike Maneuver
 Melee 1 One creature or object
Special: The target must be grabbed by the roughneck.
Effect: The target is vertical pushed up to 5 squares. An ally doesn't take damage from being force moved this way

Catcher
Melee Free triggered action
 Melee 1 The triggering creature or object
Trigger: A size 1 creature or object is force moved within distance, or a size 1 ally willingly moves within distance.
Effect: The target is grabbed by the roughneck.

Flying Sawblade
Melee Triggered action
 Self Self
Trigger: The roughneck is vertical force moved by another creature.
Effect: The roughneck uses Haymaker against a creature or object at any point during the forced movement, or after falling as a result of it.

HERO START



